Ms Lekhi also had a very telling observation. This case, she said, had created a divide between the women officers and the 'Establishment', an 'us versus them' feeling, which needed to be smoothened out. I felt that this was a very pertinent observation and then and there decided that we would introduce a First Day Cover (FDC) to mark this momentous judgment. Accordingly, on Army Day 2021, an FDC was indeed released jointly by a few women officers, Meenakshi Lekhi, myself and a few other PSOs, as an expression of good faith to let bygones be bygones and to make a new beginning.

In order to implement the Court order, a fresh draft order would have to be prepared, incorporating all the directions of the Court, for obtaining Government Sanction, without which it would not be possible to go ahead. Due to the passage of time, there were sub-categories of officers. This included those who had crossed twenty years of service and thus were already entitled to pension and those between fourteen and nineteen years of service who would have to be considered for grant of PC. Those selected would be granted PC and retained, the balance would be released but with pensionary benefits as per the Court's directions. Since these aspects had financial implications, it had to have the approval of the Finance Ministry too, before a GSL could be issued. Though we tried to speed things up as much as possible, ministerial approvals take their own sweet time. These delays were viewed adversely by the Court which felt we, i.e., the Army, were stalling for time. That was far from being the case. As Chief, I wanted to close this chapter as fast as possible.

Within the Army too, a number of issues cropped up, including the modalities for the grant of PC, which was equally complex. Should the entire cohort of affected women officers be treated as one batch or should the Selection Board be carried out year-wise and of that service, as per the comparative merit

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